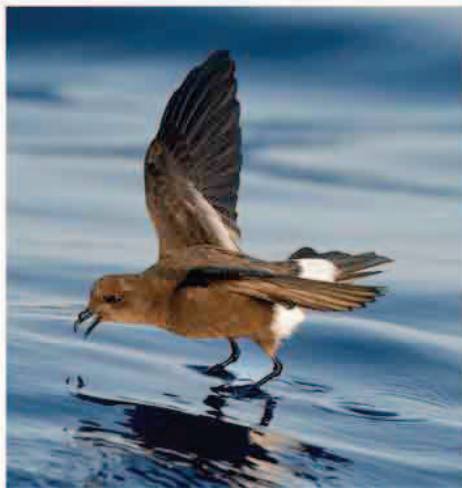




▲ WANDERING ALBATROSS

An albatross holds its long, narrow wings outspread and soars on the wind. It can cover vast distances without once beating its wings.



Petrels

Tiny but tough

Wingspan Up to 22 in (56 cm)

Range All oceans except Arctic Ocean

Hunting technique Surface feeding

Ocean birds have to cope with extreme weather and huge waves, yet some are tiny creatures that look too small and fragile to survive. They include storm petrels that are no bigger than sparrows. They spend months at sea, feeding on small animals such as krill. Many live in the Southern Ocean, and breed on the coasts of Antarctica.

Auks

Underwater fliers

Wingspan Up to 29 in (73 cm)

Range All northern oceans

Hunting technique Underwater pursuit

The auks have unusually short, strong wings specialized for “flying” underwater. This allows guillemots, razorbills, and this Atlantic puffin to catch fish by chasing after them beneath the surface. These stubby wings are not so suitable for flying through the air, so the auks have to use fast, whirring wingbeats to stay airborne.



Penguins

Flightless swimmers

Wingspan Up to 3 ft (1 m)

Range Southern coastal seas

Hunting technique Underwater pursuit

The southern equivalents of the auks are the penguins. These seabirds are highly adapted for hunting underwater, with wings that are so specialized for use as flippers that they cannot fly at all. But this makes them fast, elegant swimmers, and some of the bigger penguins can dive to amazing depths to find deepwater fish and squid. They mostly live in the icy waters of the Southern Ocean around Antarctica.

► FOOD SNATCHER

This frigatebird is forcing a tern to cough up the fish it has just caught.

Frigatebirds

Pirates of the air

Wingspan Up to 8 ft (2.4 m)

Range Most tropical oceans

Hunting technique Piracy

A few ocean birds avoid having to catch their own prey by stealing food from other birds. The most notorious of these pirates are the long-winged tropical frigatebirds,

which attack their victims in the air and force them to drop their catch. The pirates then swoop down to seize the fish in mid-air before it falls back into the sea.

